qibla wall existed: if so, it would have abutted the *minar* on the latter's east.[28] Notwithstanding the missing information, MJAP's analyses of the baked-brick flooring and other findings concluded that the encompassing structure was in all likelihood a mosque, and one to which the Shansabanis were "unlikely to have devoted fewer resources" than to the magnificent *minar* adjacent to it.[29] However, it is unknown whether the unearthed structure was the first one in that location, perhaps having superseded an earlier (smaller?) mosque and even an accompanying (less imposing?) *minar*.

It is generally assumed that Jam-Firuzkuh's *minar* (Figure 3.5) and the newly found mosque abutting it were constructed in tandem in the early 1170s, prior to which the "capital's" Muslim population – including its persistently transhumant Shansabani elite – would have prayed and gathered in humbler, less monumental or even temporary structures.[30] However, the probable absence of a Shansabani palatial complex per se (as described above) would not preclude their patronage of other structures, which, for a relatively new elite of humble origins, would have fulfilled symbolically more potent functions than the archetypal palaces of established urban rulers. Juzjani's incidental mention of Firuzkuh's *jami* and its monumental portal (*pishtaq*), where some of the plundered spoils were displayed upon their arrival from Ajmer (cf. above), implied only that the grand structure was already in place by the mid-1190s; this did not necessarily preclude the existence of an earlier structure at the site, perhaps one that was subsequently expanded or even replaced.

The Shansabanis' continued transhumance would seem to demand that some more lasting sign of their presence at Firuzkuh – such as a markedly central place for Islamic worship – serving as a steady reminder of their commanding status, perhaps especially during the initial phases of their dominance over the settled and relatively prosperous mercantile population of Firuzkuh. Based on the Shansabanis' own activity during the earlier part of the twelfth century – discussed in Chapter 2 – it is worth considering that the place of prayer unearthed by MJAP was at least initiated in the late 1140s–1150s, shortly after Qutb al-Din established himself as *malik al-jibal* at Firuzkuh, and more than two decades before the construction of the famous *minar*, which had a very pointed epigraphic program and commemorative function (cf. Chapters 4 and 5). The Shansabanis had already patronized laborers with a localized, vernacular familiarity with Persianate architectural culture when they commissioned the construction of the Da Qadi *minar*. This structure might have been ensconced within a mosque complex, and the site has tentatively been identified as Qala'-yi Zarmurgh, their *sard-sir* "capital" prior to Firuzkuh (as argued in Chapter 2). But by the mid-twelfth century, the Shansabanis' prominence and resources had risen considerably, allowing them access to skilled laborers who were *au courant* of the broader, cosmopolitan Persianate architectural trends. These